

CONSUMING FIRE
MINISTRIES INTERNATIONAL

WHAT IS CHURCH DISCIPLINE?

We believe that Church members, leaders and offenders should be disciplined according to the Bible Standards to promote good church governance and leadership. We also believe that believers must obey the laws of the nation, the Bible as well as Church principles agreed in our Church constitution and those who do not abide by the rules should be dealt with by the relevant authorities with jurisdiction to judge such matters. We believe the Leadership of the local church has the authority from the scriptures to withdraw the membership of any member for serious, unrepentant misconduct or similar cause.

What is Church Discipline?

Church discipline is the accountability process of the local church. Church members lovingly confront one another's sin and call one another to repentance. This process is most clearly outlined in Matthew 18:15-20 and 1 Corinthians 5:1-13. If someone stops repenting, and rather embraces sin as a lifestyle, the congregation responds. The final step of church discipline is a congregational decision to revoke someone's membership. The individual is no longer welcome to partake in the Lord's Supper, as the congregation can no longer see any fruit of their salvation.

How Should Church Discipline Be Done?

"Moreover if thy brother shall trespass against thee, go and tell him his fault between thee and him alone: if he shall hear thee, thou hast gained thy brother. But if he will not hear thee, then take with thee one or two more, that in the mouth of two or three witnesses every word may be established. (Dt 19:15 John 8:17 2 Cor 13:1 1 Tim 5:19) And if he shall neglect to hear them, tell it unto the church: but if he neglect to hear the church, let him be unto thee as an heathen man and a publican.Verily I say unto you, Whatsoever ye shall bind on earth shall be bound in heaven: and whatsoever ye shall loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven." (Matthew 18:15-18)

Sinning Christians can be restored by another in private and that is enough. All Christians sin and are able to confess and repent without it ever coming to church discipline. Church Discipline is the "third step" after efforts have been made to restore. Hebrews 12 along with Proverbs 3 says God "disciplines all of His sons out of love." Church discipline is done to show love to a brother or sister in Christ who is in error.

There are Four Steps in Matthew 18:

(1) Tell the sinning brother his sin alone
(2) Take some witnesses
(3) Tell the church
(4) Treat him or her as an outsider

There must be considerable evidence that a brother or a sister is committing sin or is in error or in a fault. In instances where the brother or sister has not been caught but confesses on their own that they are in a fault, their own confession is enough evidence that they need to be disciplined.

(1) Check yourself first to see if you are not guilty of the same

“Judge not, that ye be not judged. For with what judgment ye judge, ye shall be judged: and with what measure ye mete, it shall be measured to you again.And why beholdest thou the mote that is in thy brother's eye, but considerest not the beam that is in thine own eye? Or how wilt thou say to thy brother, Let me pull out the mote out of thine eye; and, behold, a beam is in thine own eye? Thou hypocrite, first cast out the beam out of thine own eye; and then shalt thou see clearly to cast out the mote out of thy brother's eye.” (Matthew 7:1-5). Before administering discipline on another believer, we need to ask ourselves some questions:

i) Is my life free from similar sin? (Romans 2:1)
ii) Do I have a relationship with the believer who has sinned that allows me to speak to them?
iii) Is my motive that of restoration rather than condemnation? (Galatians 6:1)
iv) Will I be willing to have someone else rebuke me in the same way? (Matthew 7:12)
v) Am I willing to pray for this person’s restoration, before and after confrontation? (Matthew 26:41)
vi) Is the offense truly a sin or a fault or simply an act of preference or immaturity? (Ephesians 4:2)

We use the word of God to check ourselves. We don’t compare ourselves with one another or prop ourselves up using the sins of others. “For we dare not make ourselves of the number, or compare ourselves with some that commend themselves: but they measuring themselves by themselves, and comparing themselves among themselves, are not wise.” (1 Corinthians 10:12).

(2) Address the matter with humility

“Brethren, if a man be overtaken in a fault, ye which are spiritual, restore such an one in the spirit of meekness; considering thyself, lest thou also be tempted.” (Galatians 6:1)

(3) Pray for the offender

“If any man see his brother sin a sin which is not unto death, he shall ask, and he shall give him life for them that sin not unto death. There is a sin unto death: I do not say that he shall pray for it. All unrighteousness is sin: and there is a sin not unto death.” (1 John 5:16-17)

(4) Grieve over the sinning brother

“And ye are puffed up, and have not rather mourned, that he that hath done this deed might be taken away from among you.” (1 Corinthians 5:2)

(5) We discipline offenders in humble obedience to Jesus Christ (Rev. 2:5, 14-16; 20-22; 3:1) Jesus Christ warned the churches of Asia Minor (Revelation 2-3) that if they ignored sin and would not deal with it as He instructed, then He would remove them. In obedience to the Lord and in the fear of the Lord, we seek to restore sinning saints. Those saints who refuse to be restored by repentance are to be removed in love and in reverence for Jesus Christ, the Head of the Church.

What Kind of Sin Calls for Church Discipline?

Everyone is constantly fighting sin, so what kind of sin triggers the church’s responsibility to do church discipline? The four-step process in Matthew 18 shows that it is unrepentant sin that calls the church to action. Unrepentant sin is the kind of sin that an individual gives themselves over to with no intention of turning. Even after being confronted by individuals, small groups, and by the whole church, they choose sin as a lifestyle. They befriend their sin rather than war against it and thus cease to show the fruits of saving faith that submits to Jesus as Lord. In 1 Corinthians 5, it is sexual sin that calls for discipline. In Titus 3, it is divisiveness that calls for discipline. The question of whether someone should be removed from the church’s membership is not a question of subjective severity, but whether there is repentance.

Public Rebuke

To rebuke means to reprimand and convict by exposing (sometimes publicly) a wrong. There are times when all of us need to be rebuked, and there are times when a believer needs to rebuke another believer. 1 Corinthians 16:14, says, “Let everything be done in love.” Rebuking must always be done in love and it is actually an expression of love. Whenever a child of God refuses to repent of ongoing sin in their life, “Open rebuke is better than secret love.” (Proverbs 27:5).

“Them that sin rebuke before all, that others also may fear.I charge thee before God, and the Lord Jesus Christ, and the elect angels, that thou observe these things without preferring one before another, doing nothing by partiality.” (1 Timothy 5:20-21).

“Take heed to yourselves: If thy brother trespass against thee, rebuke him; and if he repent, forgive him.And if he trespass against thee seven times in a day, and seven times in a day turn again to thee, saying, I repent; thou shalt forgive him.” (Luke 17:3-4)

Paul says, “These things speak, and exhort, and **rebuke with all authority**. Let no man despise thee.” (Titus 2:15). Some sins calls for public rebuke especially if their consequences affect the whole Church or other people in the Church. For example, sins that are most likely to cause destructive gossip in the Church require a public address. Sins with a scandalous effect that can ruin the reputation of the Church require to be censured and announced publicly within the Church to avoid breeding ground for gossip.

When a believer undermines the authority of the pastor or church leaders, they must be corrected publicly so that there is no room for them to talk behind the back of their pastor or leaders. Some believers are very good at undermining the Church leadership and blackmailing and conspiring against the leadership whilst playing like a victim. Such possibilities need to be curtailed. When people sin repeatedly, their sin may need to be rebuked publicly.

What other members of the Church should do when one member has been placed under discipline:

Other members must Care for the Sinning Christian:

Not by ignoring their sin

Not by talking about them

Not by making oneself an inspector

Not by mocking the sinning believer or spreading rumours

Not by making a joke out of their sin

Not by judging the leadership of the Church that placed the sinning brother or sister under discipline

The other Church members must pray for the sinning member to be restored and should not sympathize with their sinful behaviour.

What about being charged wrongly by the Church and disciplined under false accusations?

It is very rare but not impossible to be found guilty for a crime that you never committed. Joseph went through it all the way to prison but God restored Him. A child of God is always in the hands of God and nothing happens to a child of God without God’s permission. If it is the will of God that one has to be punished for a crime they never committed, bear with it patiently and wait upon the LORD. Do not short-circuit the process of God.

“My brethren, count it all joy when ye fall into divers temptations; Knowing this, that the trying of your faith worketh patience.But let patience have her perfect work, that ye may be perfect and entire, wanting nothing.” (James 1:2-4).